

I am worried that AI is like plastic waste.

Posted by u/HalexUwU • • 0 points • 48 comments

I'll start this off by saying a few things.

I'm an art student. I don't think AI is inherently evil or anything- I just think it's a medium, it's like a camera. Anyone who thinks AI is going to replace all artists is either stupid, or just not that great of an artist. If you genuinely can't find something that you can do better than AI, you aren't a very good artist. It is not difficult to make better artwork than AI- I know a lot of this subreddit likes to jerk off AI generated images as being so much better than human-made art, but literally anyone and everyone in the art industry understands that, while pretty, your average AI generated image is no more special than a picture on a cellphone; it might be hyper realistic, but art has never exclusively been about making something pretty.

Anyways...

My primary concern about AI, or more specifically AI generated images, is very similar to how I feel about plastic.

I think AI is often sold as "making magic from nothing" but I don't think that's accurate. While the individual cost of generating one AI image might be low, the problem has more to do with the ability to create large volumes of images. Just like plastic, a little bit of it is okay, the problem is that we've become/are becoming wasteful and reckless.

I'm worried that, in a month, a year, five years, or a decade from now we're suddenly going to be neck deep in plastic. 99% of AI generated images are single-use (if that). You generate the image, you use it once, and then it's "gone". But it's not gone. Just like plastic, those images you generate, once they're out there on the internet, they're around forever. As people continue to generate masses of images, we're going to start seeing it creep into places it shouldn't be. I already struggle to find accurate images of some birds because google images is so full of AI generated photos. How long until the internet is no longer an accurate source of information due to the prevalence of AI generated content? How long until the internet is no longer useable due to the prevalence of AI generated content? What

happens when the AI starts cannibalizing itself? We already see this happening sometimes, what about when it gets worse? What happens when AI generated images become indistinguishable from real images and the image generators can no longer identify them as possibly inaccurate?

And then there's the environmental cost. Once again, I'm sure I'll hear "but generating one AI image is less energy intensive than an artist drawing one image" which completely fails to see the forest in the trees. Yes, the cost of generating one image is cheap, but the problem is that you can generate one image, or you can generate one-hundred. It doesn't matter what the cost of generating one image is if people are generating images with a nearly 100% uptime. The cost of individual pictures might be higher for real people, but that cost--- the energy it takes to make these--- it's spread over the duration of the process. The process of prompting, selecting the images you want, and slowly widdling down an AI generated image into something you want, the process by which this subreddit often sells as "AI taking a lot of effort" inherently requires the generation of literally hundreds of images. Once again, yes the cost of generating ONE image is lower with AI, but that doesn't matter when you're generating 400+ images in the process of prompting.

A star can't burn 3x brighter for free. The things you generate have a price, both on the back and front end. If we keep borrowing time from our futures there won't be any future.

Comments

u/Princess_Spammi • 1 points • 2025-04-19 16:39 UTC

The accurate references thing is a fair point and search engines should be optimized to be able to exclude ai art, and all ai images should have embedded data that marks it as such

u/chainsawx72 • 3 points • 2025-04-19 14:40 UTC

If we keep borrowing time from our futures there won't be any future.

Sir, this is a generated image...

u/Fluid_Cup8329 • 1 points • 2025-04-19 12:49 UTC

Lmao

This is a classic case of someone desperately needing to touch some grass

u/TyrellCo • 1 points • 2025-04-19 12:04 UTC

If we suddenly implemented a carbon tax that paid to offset each carbon source to be totally net zero you would find that this would impose a very small increase in the price on AI images(only v small percent of api is energy). But bc our lives are very carbon intense then those other things the artists life touches on becomes much more expensive.